🎓 AP Lang & Composition — Cheat Sheet

Procadamia | Rhetorical Terms, Essay Frameworks & Exam Strategy

RHETORICAL SITUATION (SOAPSTONE)

Letter	Stands For	Key Question
S	Speaker	Who is writing? What's their credibility/perspective?
O	Occasion	What event/context prompted this text?
A	Audience	Who is the intended reader? What do they believe?
P	Purpose	What does the writer want the audience to do/think/feel?
S	Subject	What is the text actually about?
Tone	Tone	What is the writer's attitude toward subject/audience?

> On the exam: always identify Purpose + Audience before analyzing choices. Every stylistic decision connects back to them.

THE THREE RHETORICAL APPEALS

Appeal	Definition	Examples
Ethos	Credibility & character of the speaker	Credentials, first-hand experience, moral authority, citing experts
Logos	Logic, evidence, reasoning	Statistics, data, cause-effect, analogies, factual evidence
Pathos	Emotional appeal to the audience	Personal anecdotes, vivid imagery, word choice, tone
Kairos	Timeliness — the right moment to speak	Capitalizing on urgency, current events, opportunity

RHETORICAL DEVICES — MUST KNOW

Device	Definition
Anaphora	Repetition of a word/phrase at the start of successive clauses
Antithesis	Juxtaposition of opposing ideas in parallel structure
Chiasmus	Reversed grammatical structures ("Ask not what country can do for you...")
Parallelism	Similar grammatical structure across clauses or sentences
Rhetorical Question	Question posed for effect, not to seek an answer
Juxtaposition	Placing contrasting ideas/images side by side
Allusion	Reference to a well-known person, text, or event
Metaphor / Simile	Comparison without/with "like" or "as"
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human subjects
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration for emphasis or effect
Understatement	Deliberately downplaying something for effect
Irony	Saying the opposite of what is meant; verbal/situational/dramatic

STYLE ANALYSIS: DIDLS

Letter	Element	What to Analyze
D	Diction	Word choice — formal/informal, denotation, connotation
I	Imagery	Sensory details — visual, auditory, tactile
D	Details	Facts, observations — what writer chose to include/exclude
L	Language	Overall use of language — figurative, literal, symbolic
S	Syntax	Sentence structure — length, punctuation, fragments, inversion

> Syntax trick: short sentences = urgency/impact; long sentences = complexity or overwhelm; fragments = abruptness

ARGUMENT ESSAY STRUCTURE

Section	What to Include
Intro	Hook → context → clear, arguable thesis (takes a position)
Body ¶ 1–3	Topic sentence → evidence → commentary → link to thesis
Concession ¶	Acknowledge counterargument → refute with stronger evidence
Conclusion	Restate thesis (new language) → broaden significance → no new claims

A strong thesis: specific, arguable, and forecasts your reasoning. Avoid "I believe" — state it as fact.

⚠️ Commentary > evidence. Never let a quote "speak for itself" — always analyze HOW it proves your claim.

SYNTHESIS ESSAY RULES

- Must cite at least **3 of 6–7 provided sources**
- Cite as: **(Source A)**, **(Source B)**, etc. — no footnotes needed
- Don't just summarize sources — use them as **evidence for YOUR argument**
- Take a clear position in your thesis — synthesis essay IS an argument
- Sources can agree, disagree, or nuance each other — show the conversation
- Quotations must be introduced and followed by analysis

Best approach: read all sources → form your position → select best 3-4 that support you → outline → write

AP EXAM STRATEGY & PASSAGE ANALYSIS TIPS

Multiple Choice (MCQ)

- Read questions BEFORE the passage
- Eliminate obviously wrong answers first
- Line-reference questions → re-read 5 lines above & below
- "Purpose" Q's → think about audience + situation
- "Effect" Q's → think HOW, not just WHAT

Free Response (FRQ)

- Read prompt twice — underline the verb (analyze, argue, synthesize)
- Spend 5 min planning before writing
- Each body ¶: claim → evidence → analysis
- Score high by explaining HOW rhetorical choices achieve purpose
- Time: ~40 min per essay

Rhetorical Analysis Essay

- Thesis must identify **specific rhetorical choices**
- Don't list devices — explain WHY writer uses them
- Connect every device to speaker's purpose
- Avoid plot summary — analyze, don't narrate
- Strong verbs: asserts, challenges, underscores, juxtaposes, invokes

LITERARY TEXTS: KEY THEMES

Adventures of Huckleberry Finn (Twain)	
Central Theme	Individual conscience vs. societal norms; freedom vs. oppression
Satire	Twain uses Huck's naïve narration to mock racism, religion, "civilization"
Jim	More moral than "civilized" characters; challenges white supremacist assumptions
The River	Symbol of freedom; the shore represents danger and corrupt society
Huck's Moral Growth	"All right, then, I'll go to hell" — chooses personal morality over social law

"The Ones Who Walk Away From Omelas" (Le Guin)	
Central Question	Can collective happiness justify one individual's suffering?
The Child	Symbol of sacrificial suffering; utilitarian trade-off made literal
Those Who Stay	Accept the moral compromise; benefit from the system
Those Who Walk Away	Refuse to participate; reject the utilitarian bargain
Argument	Critiques utilitarian ethics; individual rights cannot be traded for collective joy